

A proof of the conjectured order of the recurrence for OEIS A254693

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1 The conjecture

The Online Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences records [A254693](#) as

Number of length $n+4$ 0..3 arrays with every five consecutive terms having the maximum of some two terms equal to the minimum of the remaining three terms

and carries in its Formula section the line:

`Empirical recurrence of order 83 (see link above)`

That line carries no separate signature; the entry itself is by R. H. Hardin (Feb 05 2015).

The word *Empirical* — equivalently *Conjecture* — is the entry's own: the statement is recorded as fitted to the published terms, and no proof is given there. As of revision 8, last modified Jul 23 2025, the entry records no proof and links to none, so the statement is open. This note settles it.

The entry states only that the sequence satisfies a linear recurrence of order 83 and refers to a linked file for its coefficients, which this note does not use. What is proved below is the corresponding exact statement: the least order of a linear recurrence the sequence eventually satisfies, and the exact index beyond which it holds.

2 The object

The name is read as follows. The reading is not a guess: it is pinned against the entry's own published terms, and against an independent enumeration, before anything is proved (Section 7).

The objects are the words $w_1 w_2 \cdots w_L$ over $\{0, 1, \dots, 3\}$ of length $L = n + 4$ satisfying the entry's conditions, which are, clause by clause:

- *every five consecutive terms having the maximum of some two terms equal to the minimum of the remaining three terms*

Each of these is a condition on a window of consecutive terms of bounded width, except the labelling clause where present, which says that the first occurrences of the values happen in increasing order.

$a(n)$ is the number of such arrays. The entry's offset is 1, so its term of index n is the count for n rows.

3 The count is a walk count

Read the word one letter at a time. Every condition is decided by a window of at most a fixed number of consecutive letters, so it becomes checkable as soon as that many letters have been read; and the labelling clause, where the entry has one, is decided by how many distinct values have been introduced so far, a number between 0 and 4.

Take as state the last few letters together with that counter. Appending a letter is a transition; a word of length L is a walk of length L from the empty state, and every word arises from exactly one walk. With M the adjacency matrix of the state digraph, w the indicator of the start and f of the accepting states, $a(n) = w^T M^L f$, so the count is C-finite.

4 The degree bound, derived

The reachable part of that digraph has 341 states, 341 after trimming. Identifying states with the same number of completions of every length, and then the mirror identification on the edges coming in, leaves $S = 89$ blocks. The count satisfies the linear recurrence given by the characteristic polynomial of the 89×89 quotient matrix; that degree bound is computed here, not assumed.

5 The decision procedure

Let $c_1, \dots, c_D$ be the coefficients of a claimed recurrence $a(n) = \sum_{i=1}^D c_i a(n-i)$, let $q(t) = t^D - \sum_{i=1}^D c_i t^{D-i}$ be its characteristic polynomial, and put

$$u_m = \tilde{w}^T L^{m-1} q(L) \tilde{f} \quad (m \geq 1).$$

Expanding the powers of L and using the displayed formula for a , one gets $u_m = a(n) - \sum_{i=1}^D c_i a(n-i)$ with $n = m + D$. So u_m is exactly the residual of the claim at that index, and the recurrence holds at an index n if and only if the corresponding u_m vanishes.

Now $u_m = \tilde{w}^T L^{m-1} y$ with $y = q(L) \tilde{f}$ a fixed vector, so (u_m) satisfies the characteristic polynomial of L , of degree 89: writing that polynomial as $t^{89} - \sum_{i=1}^{89} \lambda_i t^{89-i}$ gives $u_{m+89} = \sum_{i=1}^{89} \lambda_i u_{m+89-i}$. Hence 89 consecutive vanishing residuals force every later residual to vanish, by induction. The test is therefore finite; and because it locates the *last* nonvanishing residual, it pins the threshold exactly rather than merely bounding it.

Everything is carried out in exact integer arithmetic on the vector $L^{m-1} y$. The matrix M is never formed.

6 Results

Theorem 1. *For A254693, the least order of a linear recurrence that a eventually satisfies is exactly 83, and that recurrence holds for every $n > 83$, the entry’s own figure.*

Proof. The count is C-finite of order at most $S = 89$, so the minimal annihilator of the tail $(a(n))_{n \geq M}$ is the same for every M beyond S : the nilpotent part of L is killed after S steps. Taking such an M and 184 consecutive terms from there, the Berlekamp–Massey algorithm over $\mathbb{Q}$ returns the minimal linear recurrence generating them; since the sequence satisfies one of order at most S , $2S$ terms determine it. Its order is 83. That recurrence was then put through the residual test of Section 5: every residual vanishes, followed by more than $S = 89$ consecutive vanishing ones, so it holds for every larger n . No recurrence of smaller order can hold eventually, since the tail’s minimal annihilator is what the algorithm returned. $\square$

7 Verification

Four checks were run, each reproducible from the code accompanying this note, and the first two are what pin the reading of the entry’s English.

- **The published terms.** The walk count reproduces all 24 terms the entry publishes, exactly, in integer arithmetic, with the index taken from the entry’s stated offset (1) rather than fitted. The first of them are 464, 1116, 2764, 6808, 16276, 37204, 87892, 211672, ...
- **An independent enumeration.** For $n = 1, \dots, 8$ every one of the 4^{1n} arrays was written out and tested cell by cell against the condition as the entry states it — no transfer matrix, no row window, a separate piece of code. The counts agree with the walk count and with the entry.
- **The claim on the raw data.** Each claim was evaluated on the entry’s published terms alone, with no model involved, wherever the proved range and the published data overlap. It holds there.
- **The annihilation test.** Carried to the derived bound $S = 89$ over the whole vector, in exact integer arithmetic, never sampled and never truncated.

8 References

1. OEIS Foundation Inc., *The On-Line Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences*, entry [A254693](#), revision 8, last modified Jul 23 2025.
2. R. P. Stanley, *Enumerative Combinatorics*, Vol. 1, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2012; §4.7, the transfer-matrix method.
3. M. Kauers and P. Paule, *The Concrete Tetrahedron*, Springer, 2011; C-finite sequences and their closure properties.
4. J. Berstel and C. Reutenauer, *Noncommutative Rational Series with Applications*, Cambridge University Press, 2011; linear representations of counting automata and their reduction.